

During my time learning about theory in my course, I learned that empathy was a strong suit needed to guide counselors in training. However, I also realized the importance of learning about the different counseling theories. Reflecting on the Integrative Theory assignment helped me understand reality therapy, person-centered therapy, and existential therapy. I was able to acknowledge that there is no “one-size-fits-all” theory. As counselors we have to be aware of the client's needs, culture, and goals during their time in counseling which allows them to be receptive to the counseling sessions. Reflecting on my experience as a first-generation immigrant also helped me realize my “why” which is creating a safe space where individuals can feel free of judgement. I have grown from simply wanting to help others into developing a professional identity grounded in empathy, authenticity, boundaries, and advocacy. .

My Skill Development Self-Assessment showed me that becoming a counselor requires being open to feedback, reflection, and constant growth. I was able to become confident in my skills through role-play exercises in class. The skills I kept practicing with my peers consisted of open-ended questions, paraphrasing, reflection of meaning, reflection of feeling, and minimal encouragement. However, I also recognized that certain skills needed more work and practice. In the beginning, I was nervous about reflecting feelings incorrectly and the silence that clients can sometimes give. After I voiced my concerns to my professors and supervisor, I got the same feedback. Reflection of feelings can sometimes be incorrect but it is better to identify a feeling than avoid a client's emotions. My supervisor has also taught me that it is better to respond thoughtfully and remain open to correction than to avoid a client's emotions. I know my skills will continue developing, but I now approach that process with patience, self-awareness, and willingness to learn.